

sounded like a MEA media briefing.

A day before the executive, all seemed to have been lost. BJP leaders were as usual playing Mahabharat when what was needed was lines from Ramayan. It was then that Rajnath trumped his rivals by playing a master stroke. For the first time ever, Vajpayee was not attending the meeting. The maestro of communication used the letter to invoke the spirit. While prom-

Rajnath's leadership.

Advani took extra pains to showcase the bonhomie between him and the party president by relating an anecdote on his views on astrology to executive members. Apparently in 1975, an MP from Madhya Pradesh had told him that he would instead face two years of wilderness. Advani scoffed at him but soon enough Emergency was proclaimed. This episode, he said,

RAVI S SAHNI



that dominated the meet. As a result all the resolutions presented suffered from thought, ideological thrust and penmanship. The resolution on agriculture and economy was not passed as it turned out to be a cut and paste job from some earlier resolutions. The political resolution lacked gravitas. The vote-catching issue of price hike was dismissed in a few sentences; the nuclear deal and the differences between the Left and UPA were not played up as much as they should have, considering this is the issue on which the Government can fall. The powerful plank of Ram too was caught in Sangh Parivar politics. VHP was worried that Advani would hijack the agenda and wanted Joshi to prepare a separate resolution on this. In a sense, Ramayan yielded space yet again to Mahabharat.

Despite his frail health, the 82-year-old Vajpayee still remains the great unifier. His residence has become the one-stop shop to solve all familial disputes while allies like Nitish Kumar have made it clear that

SWEET SUCCESS: Vajpayee with Advani and Rajnath

WHO IS THE LEADER?

"It is a well-known fact that after Atal Bihari Vajpayee, it is L.K. Advani."

M. VENKAIAH NAIDU

"Our leader is Advaniji and Atalji is the supreme leader of the party."

JASWANT SINGH

"Sacrifices are yet to be made, the yagna is incomplete because of one's own people."

ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE

"Rajnath Singhji has done tremendous work for the organisation as the president."

LAL KRISHNA ADVANI

"At an appropriate time and forum, the party will decide its prime ministerial candidate."

RAJNATH SINGH

ising to be among them with a typical *shighra hi aapke beech aa sakunga* (I shall return to your midst soon)". He also chided the feuding factions by quoting a couplet from a poem he had written just before the BJP broke away from the Jan Sangh. The message found its mark. The campaign to oust Rajnath and coronate Advani collapsed. Advani too realised that his coronation was more a coup against Rajnath and distanced himself from it. Indeed, he took the opportunity to praise Rajnath at a public rally. It's a far cry from the June National Executive where he had criticised

made him question his own disbelief and then added "I know our party president believes in astrology". Clearly Advani was looking for meeting points, not differences, between him and Rajnath. Advani also displayed magnanimity by taking the opportunity to praise the leadership of Vajpayee at the meeting. The storm in the party blew over and the executive ended on a far different note than on what it began.

However, an opportunity to attack the Congress was clearly lost. Instead of high-brow debate that is the hallmark of BJP, it was petty squabbling

Vajpayee is the only acceptable leader.

The unsaid Bhopal resolution is to shelve the leadership question until the 'appropriate time'. While Advani will work on the allies, Rajnath will use his consensus skills to unify the factions. On the ground though, the annointment and subsequent resignation of Rajnath's son Pankaj Singh as youth wing chief in Uttar Pradesh has already given his detractors a fresh issue to break the peace. For now, Vajpayee's call of '*ao phir diya jalaen*' (let's light the lamp once again) has been answered. Until the next wind blows at it. ■